

Why Study Economics at UNBC?

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What is Economics?

Simple definition

Economics is the study of how people, businesses, and governments make choices when resources are limited.

- We all face scarcity: limited time, money, energy, and opportunities
- Because resources are limited, every choice involves a **trade-off**
- Economics helps us think clearly about those trade-offs

Example: A student wants sleep, good grades, a part-time job, friends, and time to relax. There are only 24 hours in a day.

At home

- Grocery budgets
- Saving vs spending
- Rent, mortgage, and bills

At school

- Choosing courses
- Managing time
- Deciding whether to work while studying

In society

- Inflation and wages
- Housing affordability
- Taxes and public services
- Climate policy

- **Coffee shop line:** high demand + limited supply = waiting time
- **Concert tickets:** scarce seats + huge demand = higher resale prices
- **Grocery shopping:** families substitute products when prices rise
- **Choosing a degree:** every decision has an **opportunity cost**

Opportunity cost

The real cost of a choice is the value of the next best alternative you give up.

- Why do prices rise?
- Why can jobs be hard to find?
- Why is housing expensive?
- Why do some people or places do better than others?
- How should we respond to pollution and climate change?

Inflation

Unemployment

Supply, demand, policy

Growth and inequality

Environmental economics

Key lesson: economics teaches us to look beyond the first effect and ask,
“What happens next?”

- Families deciding how to spend their income
- Students choosing their future
- Workers looking for secure jobs
- Governments deciding how to use limited budgets
- Communities trying to improve quality of life

Important point

Good economics is deeply human. It studies well-being, fairness, incentives, and the consequences of choices.

- **Labour economics**
jobs, wages, skills, unemployment
- **Health economics**
healthcare costs and policy
- **Environmental economics**
climate, pollution, sustainability
- **Development economics**
poverty, education, growth
- **Financial economics**
banking, investing, risk
- **Public economics**
taxes, spending, government policy

Bottom line: economics is broad, modern, and connected to major issues in the world.

- Traditional economics often assumes people are rational
- Behavioural economics studies how people **actually** behave
- It examines procrastination, habits, overconfidence, peer effects, and self-control problems

Examples

- Why do we buy things we do not need?
- Why do people delay saving for retirement?
- Why is “starting tomorrow” such a popular life strategy?

Behavioural economics reminds us that humans are not robots.

- Neuroeconomics connects economics, psychology, and neuroscience
- It studies what happens in the brain when people make decisions
- It helps explain risk-taking, rewards, trust, addiction, and impulsive choices

Questions it asks

- Why do people take risks?
- How do emotions affect financial decisions?
- Why does immediate reward often beat long-term benefit?

No, it does not read minds.

- Rising living costs and inflation
- Housing and affordability pressures
- Artificial intelligence and changing labour markets
- Global trade, supply chains, and uncertainty
- Climate and sustainability challenges

Why study it?

Economics gives students a framework for understanding today's world instead of just reacting to headlines.

What skills does economics build?

- Critical thinking
- Problem solving
- Data interpretation
- Decision-making under uncertainty
- Clear writing and communication
- Understanding incentives and unintended consequences

These are not only economist skills - they are career skills and life skills.

- It is practical and relevant to everyday life
- It combines numbers, ideas, and real-world problems
- It works well on its own or with business, political science, data science, environmental studies, and more
- It opens doors to many careers

Common career paths

- Government and public policy
- Banking and finance
- Business and consulting
- Research and analytics
- Law, education, and graduate study

Economics is everywhere

It helps us understand choices, incentives, markets, policy, and human behaviour.

- It is relevant to everyday life
- It helps explain major challenges in society
- It includes exciting fields like behavioural economics and neuroeconomics
- It builds valuable skills and strong career opportunities

Economics is not just a subject. It is a way of understanding the world.

Thank you!

Questions?

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